



number and password via the virtual keyboard: go to Start > All Programs > Accessories > Accessibility > On-Screen Keyboard.

It is best not to access your bank account from an Internet café. If you do not have Internet access at home, going to a friend's place is much safer. If your bank provides it, it is best to activate the SMS alert service on your account so that you're notified of every transaction you make on your account.

Phishing is a now very well-known technique whereby the e-mail address of an organisation or trustworthy person may be used to trick you into giving out your financial details or usernames and passwords. The fraudster may also send you spam or pop-up messages with links that ask you to "update," "validate," or "confirm" your account information, failing which the said account will be terminated. The link on the message will normally direct you to a Web site that looks just like a legitimate organisation's site, while being a site that exists simply to trick you into divulging information. If you fall prey, the fraudster can fake your identity and run up bills or commit crimes using your name and account(s). Thankfully, it is easy to guard against this type of menace. Most browsers today offer phishing protection; however, this is not switched on by default. To do so in IE 7, go to Tools > Internet Options > Advanced > Phishing Filter > Turn on automatic website checking. The phishing filters in browsers check every site you go to with a phishing database to check if it is legitimate or not. If you want to manually check a Web site address to see if it is a phish, go to www.phishtank.com.

Web sites of all banks and monetary services employ security certificates to validate themselves. If you are visiting a legitimate site in the latest versions of Opera, IE, or Firefox, for example, the address bar will go yellow and you'll see a "lock" icon at the end. Clicking on the lock will show you the security certificate of the site.

Most phishing addresses are easy to spot—for example, the legitimate www.abc-bank.com could be forged as www.abc-banking.com.

Another way a hacker could trick you into giving out your financial details is hacking into a friend's messenger account and sending you an instant message with a link that tells you to update your bank account details. It's a cheap trick, but it does sometimes work... remember that a friend would never ask you via IM about anything to do with money!

E-mail Scams

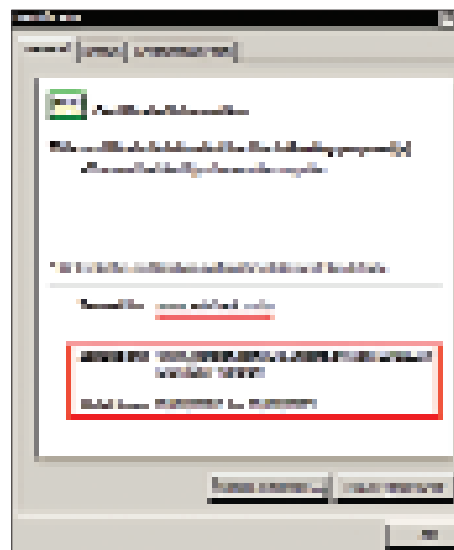
In spite of being the oldest way to trick people in to giving out details, e-mail scams continue to be the most common ways to trick people on the Web.

Even if you do exercise restraint in opening mails from unknown persons, did you know that e-mail addresses are not at all difficult to spoof? Spoofed e-mails are those that appear to have come from a trusted source, but are actually faked to appear that way. Here are the most common signs of a spoofed mail:

- ❑ A sense of urgency to take action.
- ❑ A threat: "If you ignore this, your account will be terminated."
- ❑ A link that to a Web site along with directions on what action to take.
- ❑ Requests to enter usernames and/or passwords or personally identifiable information.
- ❑ Bad grammar.

When you receive such an e-mail, answer these questions first:

- ❑ Do you deal with the bank or business in question?
- ❑ Is the e-mail to you or does it have a generic greeting like "Dear user"?
- ❑ Does it contain information about you that the company should already know, like your username or account number?



Underlined: the things to look for in a security certificate



Here's how to identify a fake e-mail

If the answer to all the above is Yes, then it is most likely a legitimate mail. Always remember, do not reply to mails that ask for personal information; if there is a phone number listed below—most legit e-mails would have this as an alternative means of contact—call and verify. And just don't click on links in e-mails from unknown contacts.

In The End...

Awareness is key—whether it's about financial crime that begins with the use of online data, or about how kids can be put at risk online. Con artists on the Web are always changing their tactics. Keep yourself updated on the latest forms of online threats and how to guard against them. It isn't difficult. ■

asfaq_tapia@thinkdigit.com